

SOLE SOURCE JUSTIFICATION

Department of Energy, Hanford Field Office

Support Services Required: Budget formulation, financial planning, strategic planning, policy analysis, and Congressional liaison functions

Requiring Organization(s): HFO Office of the Chief of Staff and Assistant Manager for Business and Financial Operations

Contracting Officer: Megan Harrison

1. **Nature and/or Description of the Action Being Approved:** This Sole Source Justification approves the award of a non-competitive, time and materials contract for specialized support services to the HFO Office of the Chief of Staff and the Assistant Manager for Business and Financial Operations. The services encompass budget formulation, financial planning, strategic planning, policy analysis, and critical Congressional liaison functions.
 - Intended Awardee: Mercia Advisors, LLC
 - Period of Performance: The award is for a one-year base period.
2. **Description of the Supplies or Services Required to Meet the Agency's Needs:** This requirement is for comprehensive, expert-level support services to the HFO Office of the Chief of Staff and the Assistant Manager for Business and Financial Operations. These services include strategic areas such as budget formulation, financial planning, strategic planning, policy analysis, and critical Congressional liaison functions. The selected contractor will also be responsible for preparing HFO staff for engagement with Congressional committees and will deliver various financial analyses, budget exhibits, briefing materials, and congressional response documents, with ad hoc analytical support as needed.
3. **Authority for Other Than Full and Open Competition (FAR 6.302-1):** This acquisition is being conducted under the authority of FAR 6.302-1, "Only one responsible source and no other supplies or services will satisfy agency requirements." This authority is applicable when the supplies or services required by the agency are available from only one responsible source, or for unique services that require a specific contractor due to their specialized nature.
4. **Demonstration that the Proposed Contractor's Unique Qualifications or Nature of the Acquisition Requires Use of the Cited Authority:**
 - **Key Argument 1: Established Relationships and Congressional Expertise:** The PWS explicitly requires established relationships and extensive experience interfacing with and supporting congressional staff on the appropriations committees. These relationships are not merely transactional; they are built upon years of trust, and direct rapport with key congressional members and staff, which Mercia Advisors, LLC possesses through its proven track record in high-stakes federal environments. The appropriations committees are highly specialized, and effective engagement demands a nuanced understanding of their processes, priorities, and unwritten rules, which can only be gained through sustained, direct experience. A contractor without these pre-existing, mature relationships and this specific depth of insight would require an extensive

and unacceptable period to cultivate them. This would jeopardize HFO's ability to secure vital funding and effectively shape legislative outcomes related to its mission requirements.

- **Key Argument 2: Interagency and Intergovernmental Coordination:** The PWS also highlights the necessity for interagency and intergovernmental coordination. This involves navigating complex stakeholder environments beyond just Congress, including other federal agencies, state governments, and various external entities critical to HFO's mission. The intended contractor possesses pre-existing, strong working relationships across these diverse groups, facilitating seamless collaboration and avoiding delays inherent in establishing new contacts and credibility.
- **Key Argument 3: Expertise in Preparing HFO Staff for High-Stakes Engagements:** The requirement to prepare HFO staff and other DOE staff to effectively engage with members of the House and Senate Armed Services committees' is paramount. This goes beyond simple briefing material preparation; it involves strategic coaching, anticipating congressional concerns, and tailoring messaging for high-stakes discussions and legislative development. This expertise is derived from a long-standing, intimate knowledge of both HFO's strategic objectives and the political intricacies of these critical committees.
- **Key Argument 4: Deep Institutional Knowledge of HFO's Mission and Funding:** The PWS mandates that the contractor understand and be familiar with HFO's mission, projects, and their relationship with HFO's funding control points. The protracted and complex nature of HFO's mission necessitates a contractor with existing, deep institutional knowledge of HFO's specific programs, historical challenges, funding mechanisms, and long-term strategic vision. Mercia Advisors, LLC, possesses this critical institutional knowledge through the direct, extensive experience of its key personnel who served as federal employee within DOE with direct knowledge of HFO operations. This background provides a first-hand, comprehensive understanding of HFO's specific programs, historical context, funding control points, and strategic priorities that is unique and immediately applicable. A new contractor without this unparalleled level of internal historical expertise would face a considerable and unacceptable learning curve, resulting in unacceptable delays, potential missteps in financial planning, and an inability to provide timely, accurate, and strategically aligned support from the inception of the contract.
- **Key Argument 5: Comprehensive Stakeholder & Policy Landscape Understanding:** The requirement for experience and knowledge of academia, special interest, and the government's administration priorities and challenges further underscores the comprehensive and unique insight required. The intended contractor has demonstrated this holistic understanding, which is essential for developing robust strategic plans and conducting thorough policy analysis that considers all relevant influencing factors.

Conclusion: Based on these unique and interconnected requirements, particularly the indispensable need for established, trusted relationships with key congressional committees, the unparalleled internal historical expertise of Mercia Advisors, LLC's key personnel regarding HFO's complex mission and funding streams, and proven expertise in high-level interagency coordination, it is determined that only Mercia Advisors, LLC, currently possesses the demonstrated, specialized capabilities to effectively perform the required services without causing substantial duplication of costs or unacceptable delays in meeting HFO's critical mission objectives.

5. **Description of Efforts Made to Solicit Offers from Other Sources:** Due to the specialized nature of these services and the critical need for existing relationships and institutional knowledge, a formal

effort to solicit offers from multiple sources is not feasible without incurring unacceptable delays and significant mission risk. However, a Notice of Intent to Award a Sole Source Contract (Notice ID 2026-DOE-AMP-0018) was published on SAM.gov on March 16, 2026, with responses due on March 26, 2026. This Notice of Intent provided an opportunity for any other interested source to demonstrate its ability to meet the requirements of the PWS. Initial market research for similar high-level strategic and congressional support services identified no other firms possessing the specific combination of established congressional relationships, interagency coordination experience, and in-depth HFO institutional knowledge required to effectively execute this PWS. Only one vendor submitted a capability statement in response to Notice ID 2026-DOE-AMP-0018 and upon review, the submission did not provide the required information as outlined in the Notice of Intent. Specifically, it did not sufficiently demonstrate their ability to meet the specified requirements for budgetary formulation, business strategy, and congressional liaison services with DOE-specific expertise, nor did it explicitly explain how they could perform the work as outlined. The lack of qualified responses further demonstrates that there is only one responsible source who can perform the scope in accordance with FAR 6.302-1.

6. **Determination by the Contracting Officer that the Anticipated Cost Will Be Fair and Reasonable:** The Contracting Officer anticipates that the cost proposed by Mercia Advisors, LLC, for these services will be determined fair and reasonable. This determination will be made prior to contract award and will be based on a comprehensive cost or price analysis in accordance with FAR Part 15.4. This analysis will include, but not be limited to, review of comparison to Government estimates, assessment of proposed labor categories and rates against market benchmarks, and/or other relevant data as appropriate.

Labor rate market research was conducted using the GSA Calculation tool: [Pricing: Hourly Labor Ceiling Rates](#). Labor categories corresponding to this action were queried for comparable data across GSA schedule contracts. Although this award will not be awarded from a GSA schedule, it serves as a tool for an independent cost estimate. Three different labor categories were queried. The first labor category, Senior Consultant, resulted in an average GSA price of \$186/hour in a range between \$150/hour and \$227/hour. The second labor category, Subject Matter Expert, resulted in an average GSA price of \$200/hour in a range between \$156/hour and \$254/hour. The third labor category, Senior Advisor, resulted in an average GSA price of \$248/hour in a range between \$188/hour and \$296/hour.

7. **Description of the Market Research Conducted:** Market research was conducted by searching for similar awards in SAM.gov and performing general internet searches to identify potential sources capable of performing this scope. This research indicated that while several firms can provide general budget or policy analysis, none possess the unique combination of established, high-level relationships with specific appropriations and armed services committees, combined with the demonstrated, direct experience and comprehensive understanding of DOE and HFO's unique mission complexities and historical financial landscape, that is essential for this requirement. The highly specialized nature of the Congressional liaison functions, particularly the reliance on pre-existing trust and rapport for critical appropriations work, combined with the need for immediate, effective support, significantly narrows the pool of potential contractors. Based on this thorough market research, Mercia Advisors, LLC, has been identified as the only firm demonstrating the required unique combination of specialized relationships, direct experience, and deep institutional understanding necessary to meet these critical requirements.

To further validate these findings and ensure no other qualified sources exist, a Notice of Intent to Award a Sole Source contract (Notice ID 2026-DOE-AMP-0018) was published on SAM.gov on March 16, 2026, with responses due on March 26, 2026, inviting any other companies capable of performing the services outlined in the PWS to submit their capabilities. Only one vendor submitted a capability statement in response to the Notice of Intent to Award a Sole Source contract was received and upon review, the submission did not provide the required information as outlined in the Notice of Intent. Specifically, it did not sufficiently demonstrate their ability to meet the specified requirements for budgetary formulation, business strategy, and congressional liaison services with DOE-specific expertise, nor did it explicitly explain how they could perform the work as outlined. The vendor stated “Our directly relevant capabilities include: Professional development and certification training (PMP, Security+)” which is does not satisfy the requirements of the PWS.

8. **Statement of the Government's Minimum Needs:** The Government's minimum needs are explicitly outlined in the attached PWS. Any reduction in the scope or quality of these services, particularly regarding the critical Congressional liaison and institutional experience requirements, would severely compromise HFO's ability to achieve its strategic objectives and manage its critical funding portfolios.

9. **Approvals:**

Technical Monitor:

Pam Zimmerman,
HFO Chief of Staff (Requiring Activity)

Contracting Officer:

Megan Harrison
Contracting Officer